

## **EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources**

**Volume 19: Jewish Mobilities Reconsidered**

**August 15-16, 2022**

**Online on Zoom**

### **Jewish Mobilities Real and Imagined: The Morpurgo Family**

Francesca Bregoli, Queens College and The Graduate Center, CUNY

Central Archive for the History of the Jewish People, Jerusalem

Archivio della Famiglia Morpurgo di Romans (P96)

*Stampa Per il Sign. Giuseppe Morpurgo qu. Dott. Sanson anco come Assuntor di Giudicio. Al laudo.*

While recent scholarship has emphasized the exceptional mobilities of early modern Jewish refugees and exiles, there is still much to be explored about the ostensibly routine movements of average Jewish women and men. Jewish merchants, physicians, rabbis, the poor, domestic servants, seasonal laborers, grooms, and brides – all these categories moved away from home for long periods on a regular basis. Short- and long-distance travel was a fact of life for early modern Jews of different ages and means. But how was such heightened mobility perceived by its protagonists, what emotional baggage did it carry, and how was the resulting distance bridged? My presentation will approach the issue of Jewish mobility in its relation to familial bonds, by which it was often sustained, but which it also deeply affected.

The four early 18<sup>th</sup>-century texts presented here are excerpted from the correspondence of two members of the Morpurgo family based in Romans d'Isonzo (Gorizia) and Salonika with their son and brother, respectively, who lived in Ancona. They offer a synthetic sample of some of the motivations and necessities that underpinned mobility for Jewish men and women and how it impacted their household, including the desire to flee and go into hiding to escape bankruptcy; traveling to commercial fairs; the need to find distant domestic work to cope with an economic downturn; and the mobility of merchants with its challenges and opportunities.

Both the genre and the format of these sources are worth discussing. In the absence of face-to-face communication, distant relatives of course resorted to correspondence, the vagaries of which were frequently commented upon in the letters themselves. The Morpurgo letters have not come down to us in a coherent manuscript collection, however. Rather, they are included as legal evidence in a pamphlet prepared at the conclusion of a family lawsuit, as if representing ghostly remnants of family ties that would become too frayed a generation later.

In 1778 Giuseppe Morpurgo of Ancona, the son of renowned rabbi and doctor Sansone Morpurgo (1681-1740) and a successful long-distance merchant, won a protracted lawsuit originally brought against him by his cousin Isacco, based in Venice. Isacco had advanced pretenses over Giuseppe's assets on the ground that Sansone and his brother David (Isacco's father and a merchant in Salonika) had decades earlier constituted a "fraternal partnership" (*fraterna*), claiming that arrangement was still binding. After his legal victory, Giuseppe had a pamphlet published which included all evidence brought during the case, as well as the sentences. The letters under discussion were included to support the defense strategy of Giuseppe's lawyer, who successfully argued that the Ancona and Venice branches of the family were economically independent and no *fraterna* was standing.

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Letter written by Salvador Moisè Morpurgo of Romans on June 4, 1710 to [his son] Exc. Doc. Sanson Morpurgo of Ancona (pp. 27-29)

[NB: This long letter is one single sentence in the original Italian. I have broken up the text to facilitate comprehension]

I did not answer your last letter because I knew [my reply] would arrive before the Holiday, and I did not want to sadden you with this unexpected piece of news, which I know well you won't approve of, but necessity knows no law; for a desperate Soul we cannot hope anything other than a similar, truly horrible resolution. Thinking it over and over, it seems to me that [such a resolution] will cause the least damage to those who stay, therefore I decided to leave the Fatherland, and go where my poor Legs will be able to take me, to mimic Agar when she abandoned Ishmael not to see [him] die of thirst; and so as not to see my Wife, and Daughters, [and] Grandchildren die of hunger I assure you that I will endeavor to travel as far away from the Fatherland as possible, and that I will hide my Name and Last Name to avoid any damage to you, and to our Relatives. At least I'd like for you too to act charitably, praying for my Soul in your Prayers. Since I don't hope to be able to communicate to you the news of my Death, when

it pleases God [i.e., any time soon], please act charitably and preventatively [through your prayers], so that I will at least know that my Soul has greater hope for solace, as God wants my fate to be such: I am abandoned by Relatives, and Sons, and without any Friends, the way things go now. I only hope in God, and since wandering about is crimeless I hope by doing so to erase my crimes as well. And with my Funeral, which I beg you and David, to whom I'm sending a different letter of the same tenor, to carry out, I hope to at least find comfort in Heaven and have a resting place, when it will please the Lord God. May He have mercy on me, although I have no merits, and guard you and the others, and give you his blessing, and confirm my benediction, which I offer you from [lit. with] the inside of my Heart, and who knows if God won't have mercy of these poor Souls and give them his blessing once I go through with my resolution, because God can lift [people] up out of nowhere. And where thousands of Poor people live, He won't help me as well, as I remember that when I listened to [your decision] to leave Padua you told me repeatedly that "wandering the world" is said about two types of People, and I am one of them. If I had wanted to come to the Fair [of Senigallia] I would have come because I believed you might like it, [but] since I notice that you don't, I yearn, and have always yearned to satisfy you. Unfortunately, in the same way as I have decided today [i.e., to leave], soon it will be opportune for Elia Vita etc. to do the same with his Wife and Children. You say that I think everything is easy, yet sadly I know that everything is difficult, but ultimately, it's better to say let's throw oneself in God's arms. I am ending [this letter] since I have too much to say; once again please pray for me, and a desirable Death from such a Life, and again hugging you I remain your most cordial, afflicted Father, [and] send greetings.

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Lettera scritta da Salvador Moisè Morpurgo di Romans il dì 4 giugno 1710  
all'Eccell. Dot. Sanson Morpurgo d'Ancona (pp. 27-29)

Non ho risposto la passata perché sapeva vi capitava avanti Festa, ed non ho volsuto ramificarvi lo stesso con questa inaspettata nova, che a ben sò non sarà approvata da voi, ma necessità non ha legge, di un'Anima disperata non si pol sperar altro che simile fin orrende rissoluzione dove io pensando, e ripensando mi par di ripigliarmi al meno mal per chi resta qual ho stabilito di allontanarmi dalla Patria, e portarmi sino dove le mie povere Gambe mi sapranno portar per imitar Agar quando abbandonò Ismael per non veder a morir di sete, e io per non veder a morir di fame Moglie, e Figliuole, Nepote, vi accerto che procurarò allontanarmi dalla Patria più che potrò e che tenirò celato il mio Nome, e Cognome per non portar pregiudicio né a voi, né alli Parenti, & almanco vorrei che anco voi usaste meco una Carità di pregar nelle vostre Orazioni per la mia Anima, che non essendo in speranza di potervi far pervenir la nuova della mia Morte quando piacerà ad Iddio, vorrei mi facesti la Carità di prevenir con la suddetta acciò sappia almeno, che per l'Anima abbia più speranza di sollievo, che il Dio la mia sorte vuol così, son abbandonato da Parenti, e Figli, privo di Amici all'uso moderno tanto non spero, altro che nel Iddio, e perché l'andar rammingo è purgo di delitti spero con lo stesso ancor io di scancellar li miei dilitti, e con l'Esequie, che vi prego

continuarmi voi, e David, al quale spedisco una non simile ma di questo tenore, restare almeno consolato nel Paradiso, & avere un posto di riposo quando piacerà al Signor Iddio al quale anco io abbenchè senza meriti prego aver pietà di me, e conservi voi, e li altri, e vi dia la sua benedizione, e confermi la mia quale vi porgo con l'interno del mio Cuore, e chi sa, che quando sarà seguito la mia risoluzione il Signor Iddio non abbia pietà di queste pover'Anime, & che dia la benedizione alli stessi, perché Dio può sollevare in un punto, & dove vivono a migliaia de Poveri non mi assisterà ancora a me perché mi sovviene, che quando vi ascoltava io voi ad allontanarvi di Padova più volte mi dicesti, che andar per il Mondo è detto per due qualità di Persone dove io ne sono uno di quelli, se voleva venire in Fiera venivo perché stimava fosse di vostro gusto, e giacché scorgo, che vi riesce di disgusto io bramo, ed ho sempre bramato incontrar le vostre soddisfazioni, pur troppo che come oggi risolvo io, & a momenti converrà fare l'istesso anco Elia Vita etc. con Moglie, e Creature, voi dite, che io stimo tutto facile, pur troppo che conosco tutto difficile, ma finalmente è meglio dir giettiamoci in braccio a Dio faccio fine perché ho troppo di dire, da rinovo vi prego pregar per me, & desiderabile la Morte da tal Vita, e di novo abbracciandovi come cordialissimo Padre afflitto resto, vi saluto.

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Letter written by Salvador Moisè Morpurgo of Romans on June 30 1712 to his Son, Exc. Doc. Sanson Morpurgo of Ancona (pp. 36-37)

[...] Yesterday Caliman Cormons came by, who hadn't thought of going to the Fairs at all, and neither did Montefior, [but] both of them decided [to go] out of the blue, and if you have a conversation with him at the Fair he will give you a precise report of our miseries, which he knows all too well in great detail, so much so that in order to earn 20 Lire I decided to arrange for your Mother to go to Gorizia at Aron's to take over from Siporà to spin Silk; you can well imagine the point I've reached by letting her go to work as a Domestic in someone else's Home, that at least she will have Food for three or four weeks without having to scrape by at Home. If you come to Venice, it would not be a bad idea to travel Home, otherwise it will be necessary for us to travel there, but very reluctantly since neither she nor I have anything left (lit. we have nothing on our bodies). [...] We have no news of David, so if you hear anything please send word, and in the meantime offering you my blessing together with our Lady Daughter-in-Law [i.e., Sanson's wife], I remain [your Father], greeting you.



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Lettera scritta da Salvador Moisè Morpurgo di Romans nel dì 30 giugno 1712 a suo Figlio Ecc. Dott. Sanson Morpurgo d'Ancona (pp. 36-37)

[...] Geri fu da me Caliman Cormons, che per insogno non aveva pensier di venir in Fiere, né tampoco Montefior, e si sono rissolti ambidue in un punto, con il quale se vi abboccarete in Fiera vi saprà dar distinto ragguaglio delle nostre miserie, che lui il sa pur troppo minutamente, a segno tal che per veder di guadagnar Lire 20 ho risolto far, che vostra Madre vada a Gorizia da Aron a dar cambio a Siporà per el trar di Seda, dove imagatevi a che estremo son ridotto, a lasciarla andar a far la Massera in Casa d'altri, che almeno qualche 3 o 4 settimane avrà il suo Vito senza penarlo a Casa. Se verrete a Venezia non sarà mal fatto un Viaggio a Casa, in difetto converrà far noi il Viaggio colà, ma molto mal volontieri perché né essa, né io abbiamo niente in dosso. [...] Di David non si sa né nova né novella, che sapendo vi qualche cosa m'avisarete, e nel mentre con porgervi la mia benedizione assieme con la Siora Nora resto salute.

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Letter written by Salvador Moisè Morpurgo of Romans on December 7 1713 to the Excell. Doc. Sanson Morpurgo of Ancona his Son (p. 38)

[...] I cannot quiet down about such a big disregard from my David, it is about a Year that he is in Constantinople, where there is [an efficient] Land Postal Service, and on top of that it's possible to send Letters from there to Venice, and that he's never even written two lines, neither Home nor to you, God willing he is well, he has never been so neglectful, and whenever we will hear something it couldn't come soon enough; that's it for now, only to offer you my blessings together with your Spouse and Grandchildren [i.e., Sanson's children] (?), I remain greeting you. Your Mother won't write, since she is cold.

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Lettera scritta da Salvador Moisè Morpurgo di Romans il dì 7 dicembre 1713  
all'Eccell. Dott. Sanson Morpurgo d'Ancona suo Figlio (p. 38)

[...] Non mi posso aquietar d'una trascuragine così grande del mio David, che sarà un Anno, che si trova in Costantinopoli, dove corre Posta per Terra, & in oltre hanno le Lettere a Venezia, e che mai abbia scritto due righe, né a casa né a voi, il Signor voglia sia per bene, non ha mai trascurato tanto, ogni qual volta vi saprà qualche cosa sarà ora, non altro per ora solo con porgervi le mie benedizioni, unito con vostra Consorte, e Nepoti resto di saluto.

Vostra Madre, non scrive che ha freddo.

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Letter written by David Morpurgo of Salonika of January 18 Gennaro 1735 to His Brother, the Exc. Doc. Sanson Morpurgo of Ancona (pp. 56-58)

I am aware that I owe you an answer to various letters, the best one [?] on October 31, and I acknowledge the match that could be arranged for our other Niece in Romans with the Son of B. Fait Fermi, who seems to me an excellent prospect; and concerning your request for [monetary] assistance to carry this out, if our Brother and his Wife agree [to the match], although the past year has been critical for me, I entrust myself to God Blessed be He, who will give me a way to be able to provide, you can pledge 100 Scudi on my behalf, and all this in order to quiet down those two Old people, as you wisely say. The decision you took about my dear Moisè Vita [Sanson's son] was a consolation to me, and I pray (God) [sic: likely Hebrew in the original manuscript] that He let you see this joy accomplished, and when the time comes to find out, that he will go on for a Doctorate, and the good success of my Godson [?], who demonstrated his spirit from the start, may God Blessed be He keep him healthy for his holy service. I am preparing my Spouse to allow me to embark on a trip so I will be able to hug you when Seppilli comes back, and I have not lost hope that I will obtain her permission, since she has a very docile temperament, but the thought of leaving my dear Children for such a long time is a serious obstacle, but I do still hope that Fraternal Love will surpass Paternal Love. [...]

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Lettera scritta da David Morpurgo di Salonico del dì 18 Gennaro 1735 all'Ecc. Dott. suo Fratello Sanson Morpurgo d'Ancona (pp. 56-58)

Mi conosco debitore di risposta a diverse vostre la meglio di 31 Ottobre, e vedo l'incontro vi sarebbe per l'altra Nipote di Romans con il Figlio di B. Fait Fermi, che parmi buonissimo partito, e perciò, che mi richiedete di soccorso per l'effettuazione quando il Fratello, e la Moglie vi concorre, e nonostante che l'anno passato è stato per me critico, affidato a Iddio Benedetto, che mi darà il modo di poter supplire, vi potete impegnare per me Scudi 100, tutto affine di quietare quelli due Vecchi, come voi saviamente dite. Mi fu di consolazione poi la risoluzione prendeste per il caro Moisè Vita che prego il (Dio) [sic: likely Hebrew in the original manuscript] vi lasci veder compita l'allegrezza, e al tempo del scoprirsi sentire, che passerà al Dottorato, e la buona riuscita del mio Compadrino, che da suo principio ha dimostrato il suo spirito, Iddio Benedetto gli conservi in salute per suo santo servizio. Io vado disponendo l'animo di mia Consorte a permettermi di far un viaggio tanto per potervi abbracciare al ritorno di Seppilli, e non dispero di ottenerne la permissione per esser ella d'un naturale assai docile, ma il pensare di lasciar per un lungo tempo li cari Figli, mi si fa un grande ostacolo, ma pure spero, che supererà il Fraternal al Paterno amore. [...]